GLOBAL MISSING MIGRANTS DATASET

Decision brief | Descriptive analysis of documented incidents

Purpose: summarize patterns in the supplied dataset to support evidence-informed discussion, data-quality improvement, and humanitarian coordination. This is a descriptive analysis of recorded cases, not a complete count of all migration-related deaths or disappearances.

13,020	19	2014–2023	1.5%
Records	Columns	Incident-year span	Cells missing

Executive summary

• The dataset contains incident-year values from 2014 to 2023. The annual chart shows documented records by year, which may reflect reporting and documentation patterns as well as underlying events.

• The most frequently recorded incident region is “North America” (2,706 records, 20.8% of all rows). This is a share of records in this dataset, not a risk rate or population-adjusted comparison.

• The most frequently recorded migration route is “US-Mexico border crossing” (3,392 records). This can help prioritize data review and coordination, but does not by itself estimate the probability of harm on that route.

• The most frequently recorded cause/incident description is “Drowning” (3,313 records). Categories may include uncertain or mixed descriptions; interpret as recorded classifications.

• For records with a non-missing, non-negative reported total of dead and missing, the median is 1, the mean is 4.42, and the 90th percentile is 7. The mean exceeding the median would indicate a right-skewed distribution influenced by larger incidents.

Decision implications

• **Prioritize coordination, not ranking alone.** Use regions and routes with high recorded counts to review operational coverage, reporting access, and referral pathways. Do not interpret counts as risk rates without exposure or denominator data.

• **Strengthen data completeness.** Track missingness in incident date, location, route, cause, and reported totals. A consistent data dictionary and validation rules can improve comparability.

• **Separate incident frequency from severity.** Record counts and reported deaths/missing totals answer different questions. Review both, and inspect extreme incidents individually.

• **Interpret trends cautiously.** Changes over time may reflect reporting capacity, source coverage, definitions, and access—not only changes in real-world incidents.

• **Protect vulnerable people.** Avoid publishing precise coordinates or granular details that could expose survivors, families, or people in transit to additional risk.

1. Recorded incidents over time

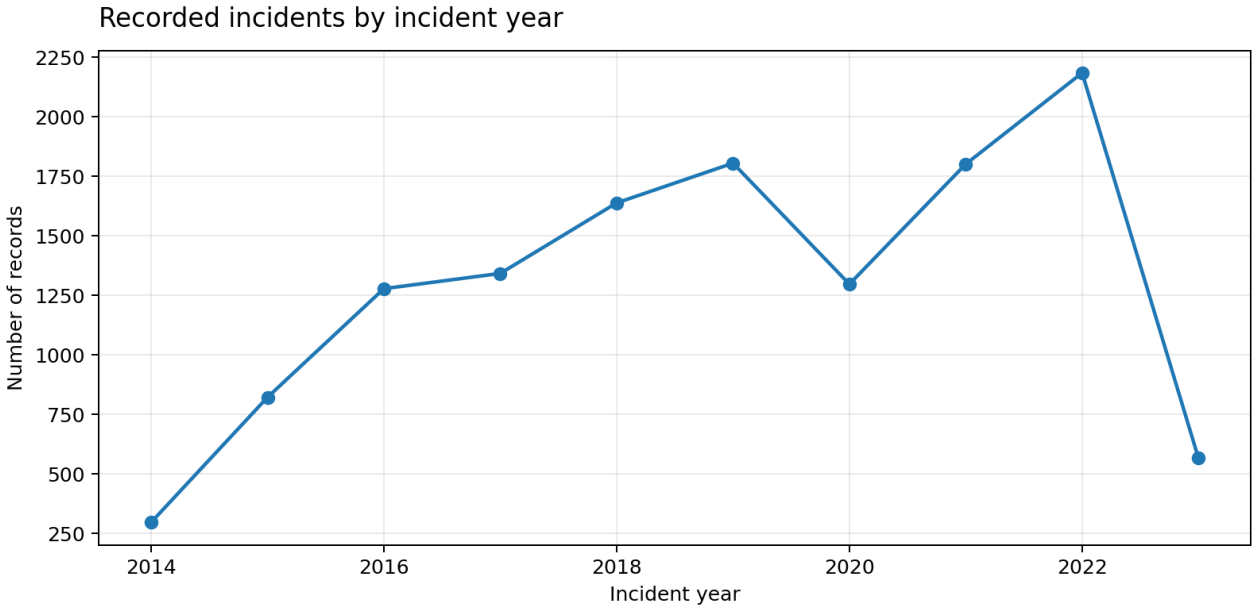


Figure 1. Annual number of records for the most recent 25 incident years available in the dataset. This is a count of documented records, not a complete incidence rate.

How to use this chart: identify periods with more or fewer documented records, then check whether reporting sources, geographic coverage, or definitions changed. Avoid forecasting future incidents from this chart alone.

2. Regions with the most recorded incidents

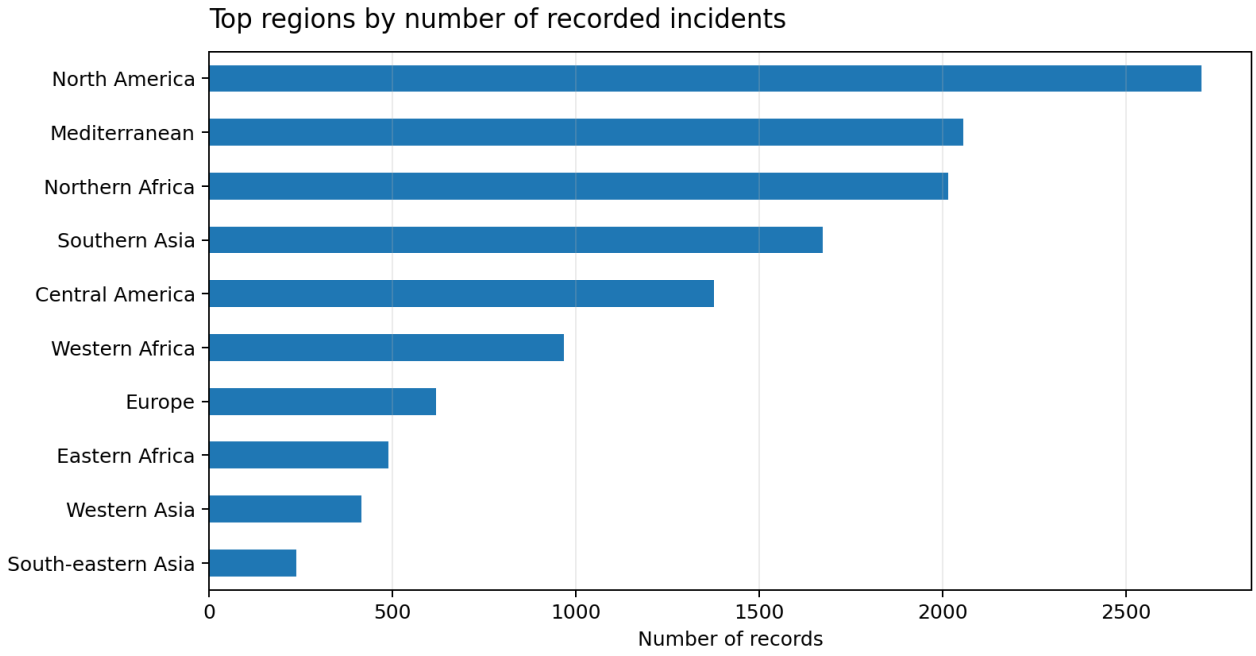


Figure 2. Top regions of incident by number of dataset records.

Region	Recorded incidents
North America	2,706
Mediterranean	2,055
Northern Africa	2,014
Southern Asia	1,673
Central America	1,375

Region	Recorded incidents
Western Africa	967
Europe	619
Eastern Africa	489

3. Migration routes

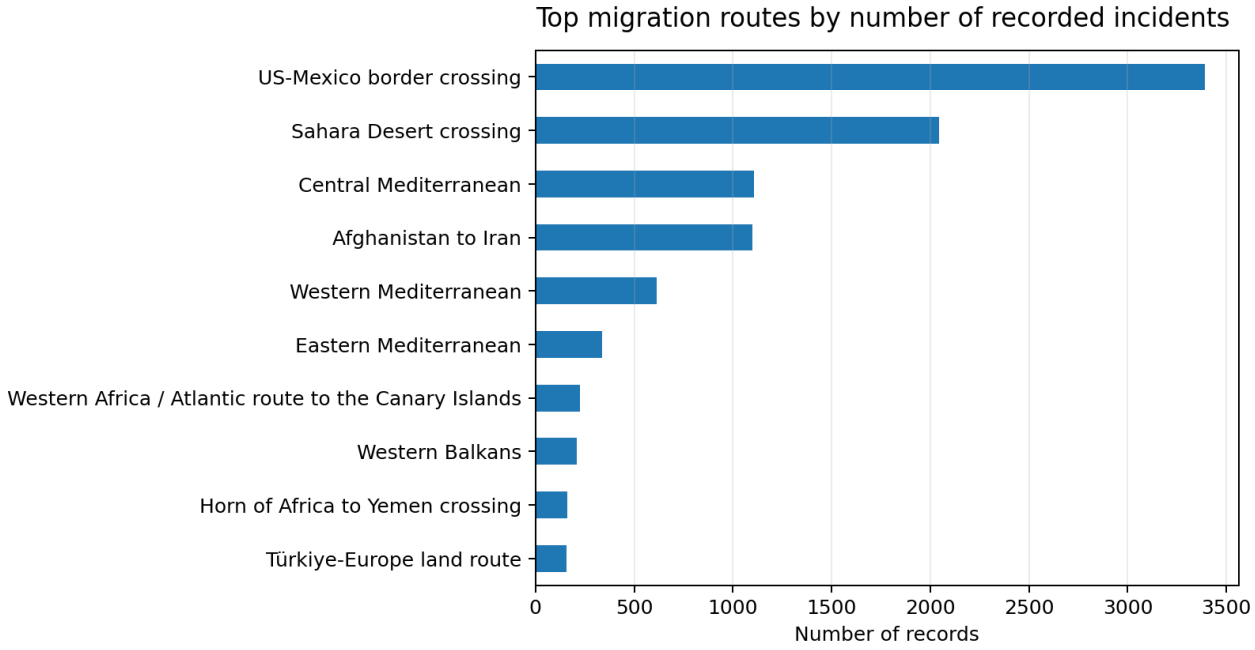


Figure 3. Top migration routes by number of recorded incident rows.

Decision use: combine route-level records with trusted operational information, survivor support needs, and data coverage. High record counts alone cannot show the probability of harm on a route because the number of people travelling and the completeness of reporting are unknown.

4. Recorded causes / incident descriptions

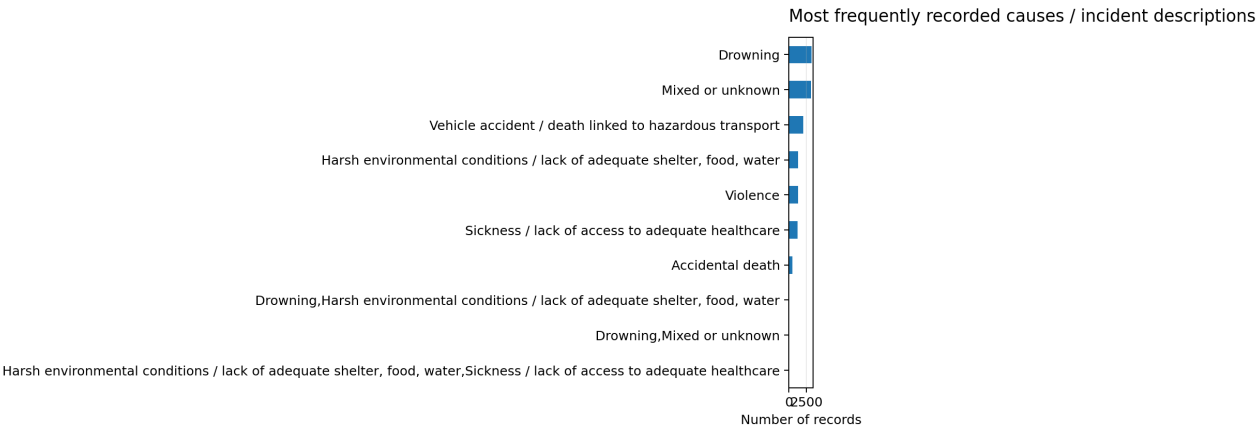


Figure 4. Most frequently recorded cause-of-death or incident-description categories.

Decision use: examine the categories with the highest counts to identify where prevention messaging, emergency response, or data coding may need review. Confirm category definitions before comparing groups; free-text or mixed classifications can limit interpretation.

5. Reported deaths and missing persons per record

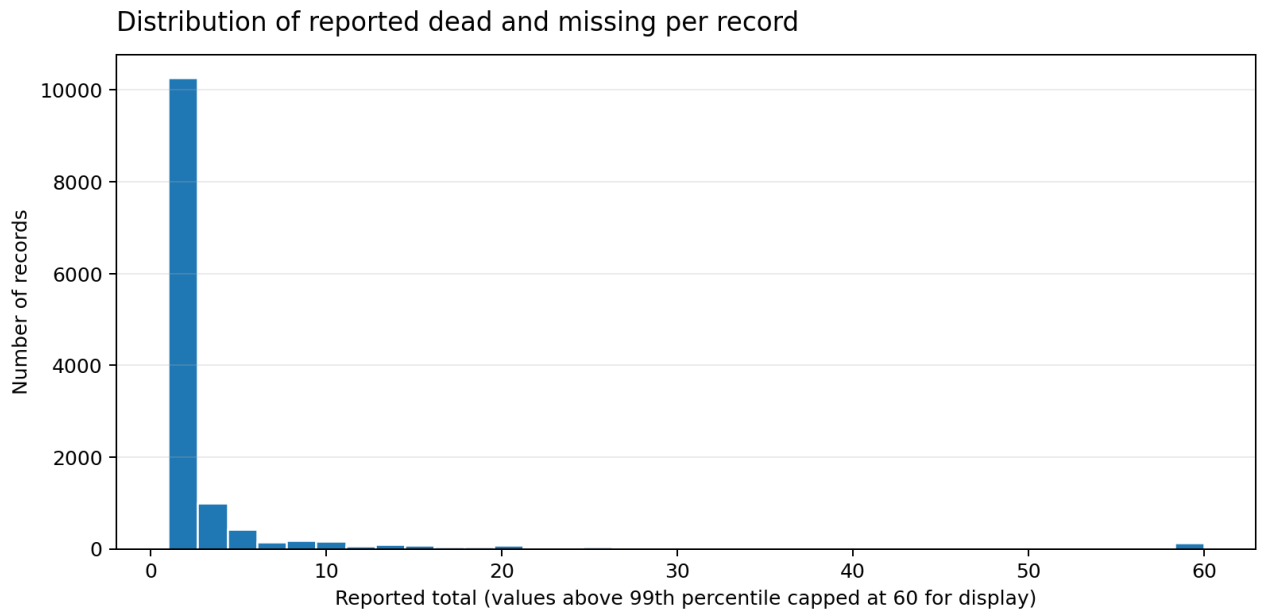


Figure 5. Distribution of reported dead and missing persons per record. For visual readability, values above the 99th percentile are capped only in the chart; summary statistics use uncapped values.

Statistic	Value
Records with a reported total	13,020
Median per record	1
Mean per record	4.42
90th percentile	7
Maximum reported total	1,022
Sum of reported totals (not a verified unique-person count)	57,513

Caution: totals may include estimates and may not represent unique individuals. The dataset includes a minimum estimate of missing persons and separate reported totals; definitions and overlap should be checked before aggregating across records.

6. Data quality and limitations

• The file contains 13,020 rows and 19 columns.

• 3,646 cells are blank (1.5% of all cells). Missingness varies by field; inspect the data dictionary before analysis.

• 641 exact duplicate rows were detected. Review them rather than automatically assuming they are errors.

• The data is observational and documentation-dependent. Missing records and blank fields are not proof that no incident occurred.

• Cross-region or cross-route comparisons should ideally account for migration volume, reporting coverage, time period, and consistent definitions.

• Location fields may be approximate or sensitive; public outputs should avoid unnecessary precision.

7. Recommended actions

Horizon	Recommended action
Immediate	Validate the most recent records and the fields with high missingness; confirm incident date, region, route, cause, and reported totals.

Horizon	Recommended action
Near term	Develop a standard data dictionary, controlled categories, and a routine quality dashboard tracking completeness, duplicate review, and late reporting.
Operational	Use documented patterns to guide where to review reporting coverage and coordination needs, not as a stand-alone risk ranking.
Analytical	If feasible, combine these records with denominators such as estimated route traffic, time-at-risk, and reporting-source coverage before estimating comparative risk.
Governance	Apply privacy and safeguarding review before sharing granular location or incident details.

Methodology note

This brief was generated from the supplied CSV using Python and Pandas. Charts summarize record counts and reported values as stored in the file. Column values were not independently verified against external sources. Any decision should be triangulated with operational knowledge, current humanitarian assessments, and the dataset's documentation.